

Theories of International Relations

- Theories of international relations allow us to understand and sense of the world around us through various lenses.
- IR theories present contending theories about the nature of international politics.
- IR theories are divided in to three
 - traditional theories, aka mainstream IR theories
 - middle-ground theories and
 - critical theories

1. Main stream IR theories

Liberalism/Idealism

- This theory aka **Utopian**
- Views human being as naturally good, peace loving and cooperative
- Believes on the relevance of morality, diplomacy and cooperation in international politics.
- It focuses on “what it should be”
- Believes that **peace** and **cooperation** are achievable.
- The theory is influenced by philosophers like **John Locke** and **Immanuel Kant**.
- Immanuel Kant developed the idea in the late eighteenth century that states that share **liberal values** should have no reason for going to war against one another.
- Kant’s idea influenced the emergence of the **Democratic Peace Theory (DPT)**, which argues that **democracies do not go to war with each other**.

Why democracies do not go to war?

- Their citizens do not allow tax payer’s money to be used for war
- They solve their problems via peaceful means
- They have faith on institutions and diplomacy to solve emerging problems eg. LN (1920)

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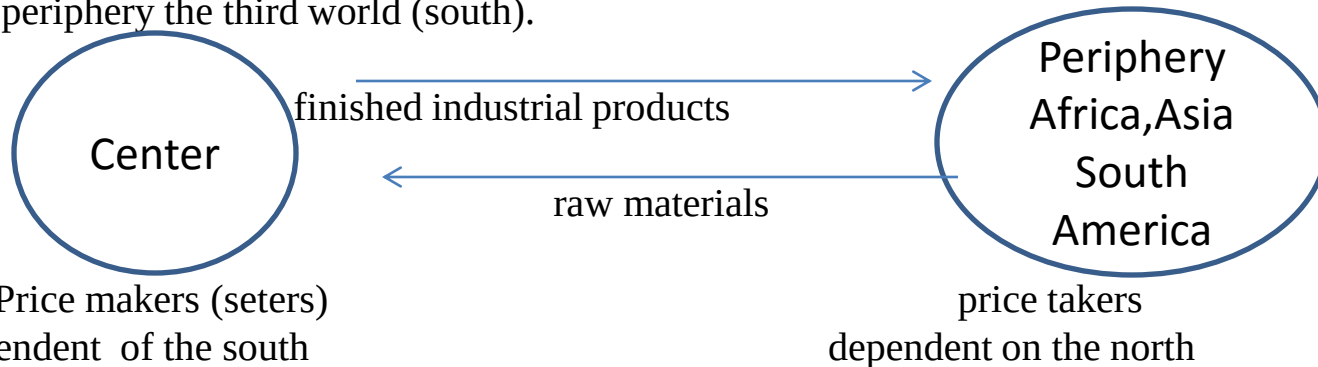
- Liberalism /idealism believes in **liberal internationalism** which says the academic study of international relations had the potential to contribute to the prevention of war and the establishment of peace.
- **liberal internationalism** argues that the prospects for the elimination of war lay with a preference for **democracy** over **aristocracy**, **free trade** over **autarky**, and **collective security** over the **balance of power** system' (Burchill, 1996: 31).
- **democracy and free trade**, are the two formative pillars of liberal internationalism, required the establishment of international relations which promote collectivist aspirations than competition.

2. Realism

- aka real politik
- Considers human nature as selfish, evil, conflictual, competitive, war mongerer,etc
- It focuses on “what really is”
- Views that the international system is ‘anarchic’- absence of global governance.
- Conflict is an inevitable and continual feature of inter-national relations.
- Thucydides, Machiavelli and Hobbes are the founding voices of realism
- It believes in power and balance of power which is the source of peace
- Argues that states are the primary and the only actors of IRs.
- State survival, accumulation of power, national interest are key concepts of realism.
- Power is the means to an end- survival in the **Darwinian** world.
- The International system is a self-help system.
- If you need peace, then prepare for war.

Structuralism/Marxism

- In Marxist terminology structuralism refers structures which promote **economic** and **class** domination.
- Marxism argues that a capitalist society is divided into two contradictory classes – **the business class** (the bourgeoisie) and the **working class** (the proletariat).
- Marx hoped for an eventual end to the capitalist society and overthrow of the bourgeoisie by the proletariat.
- International **socialist revolution** is the only solution for global peace since socialists do not fight imperialist wars.
- Focuses on the inequalities that exist within the international system, inequalities of wealth between the rich 'North' or the 'First World' and the poor 'South' or the 'Third World'
- Is a paradigm focused on dependency, exploitation and the international division of labor which relegated the vast majority of the global population to the extremes of poverty,
- Structuralism focuses on center-periphery relations or **division of labor**. The center being the west (north) and the periphery the third world (south).



- Effect: 1. global inequality
2. debt burden
3. violence and instability

which were caused by
Imperialism of the capitalist west
Social (state) capitalism by USSR

- Major contributors of dependency theory are **Latin American**, **African** and the **Middle East** scholars
- **Immanuel Wallerstein's** world systems analysis provided a historicist account of the spread of capitalism from the sixteenth century to the present, providing a definitive statement on the impact of this structure on interstate, class and other social relations.

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Constructivism

- Constructivism is a theory commonly viewed as a middle ground IR theory.
- the importance of values and shared interests between individuals who interact on the global stage.
- argues goals of state are shaped by their ideas and values
- Alexander Wendt, a prominent constructivist, described the relationship between **agents** (individuals) and **structures** (such as the state) as one in which structures not only constrain agents but also construct their identities and interests.

Eg. **US**, as the bastion of liberal idea

Iran (IRI) as the Islamic revolutionary state (1979) and defender of Shia sect

KSA, defender of Orthodox Islam (Sunni sect)

Israel, the only Jew and democratic state encircled by reactionaries, despotic and others

DPRK, committed to the building of socialism and fighting US's imperialism.

Ethiopia, Christian island in the sea of infidels – this was during emperor Hailesilassie I.

- International anarchy as the defining principle of international politics, it has become part of our reality.
- Anarchy is what actors make of it.
- To understand constructivism is to understand that ideas, or 'norms' as they are often called, have "power".
- IR is fundamentally political, normative, socially constructed and interest-driven.

Critical Theories

- Critical approaches refer to a wide spectrum of theories that have been established in response to mainstream approaches in the field, mainly **liberalism** and **realism**.
- they oppose commonly held assumptions in the field of IR
- call for new approaches that are better suited to understand, as well as question, the world.
- They identify positions that have typically been **ignored** or **overlooked** by mainstream IR theories.
- They provide a voice to individuals who have frequently been marginalized.
e.g. **Women, the global south, minorities, stateless peoples**
- Critical theories influenced by Marxism, oppose the internationalization of the state which led ordinary people around the globe becoming **divided** and **alienated**.
- They call that the legitimacy of the state must be **questioned** and ultimately **dissolved**.
- **emancipation** from the state is their wider agenda for the world.
- **Feminism, critical theory, post-modernism** are sub theories of Critical theories.

Post-colonialism

- focuses on the inequality between nations or regions.
- effects of colonialism are still felt in many regions of the world today as local populations continue to deal with the challenges created and left behind by the former colonial powers.
- Post-colonialism's origins can be traced to the Cold War period when much activity in international relations centered around decolonization and the ambition to undo the legacies of European imperialism.
- Edward Said (1978) developed the prominent 'Orientalist' critique, describing how the Middle East and Asia were inaccurately depicted in the West or **Euro-centrism**.
- Orientalism focuses on including the viewpoints of those from the Global South to ensure that Western scholarship (Euro-centrism) no longer spoke on their behalf.
- Euro-centrism signifies the **cultural, moral** and **rational** aspect (superiority) of the Western world and its dominance over the other.
- Afro-centrism, Orientalism are counter scholarships that focus on the centrality of Africa and Asia in their own knowledge production other than 'Western' mindset.